THE CITIES OF THE LEMRO VALLEY (11TH TO THE 15TH CENTURIES)

From the 11th to the 15th centuries a series of small Arakanese cities emerged along the lowlands west of the Lemro River, as the alluvial flood plains of the valley proved ideal for cultivation. Little is known about the early history of the cities of the Lemro valley. It is thought that the earliest indigenous inhabitants were the Chin, Kami, Mro, and Sak tribes. The Arakanese (Rakhine) are thought to be of Tibeto-Burman origin, who began crossing the Arakan Yoma Range in the ninth century. The Arakanese eventually displaced the indigenous tribes of the Lemro valley. The Arakanese went on to found a series of settlements at Sambawak (794–818), Pyinsa (818–1103), Parein (1103–1123), Hkrit (1142–1154), second Sambawak (1154–1163), Myohaung Toungoo (1163–1251), and Launggret (1247–1433), along the banks of the Lemro River. These royal capitals had both cultural and political links to Bagan. Capitals changed as succeeding dynasties moved locations to suit either political or military objectives.

The oldest city, Sambawak, is believed to have been built by Saw Shwe Lu (r. ca. 794–818), a descendent of the Candra kings of Vesali on the west bank of the Lemro River in 794. Invasions of Tibeto-Burman tribes from the east and the revolt of the native Sak tribe destabilized the kingdom. Unable to defend itself from neighboring Bagan's military might, Sambawak eventually became a part of Bagan. According to different Arakanese chronicles, Pyinsa was founded by Nga Ton Min (r. ca. 818–828). Twelve kings ruled the city for over 250 years during a period of relative calm and stability. It was during a period of political turmoil during the reign of Min Bilu (r. ca. 1075–1078) that a noble named Thinkhaya (r. ca. 1078–1092) assassinated Min Bilu, usurping the crown and forcing the royal family to seek refuge at the court of the king of Bagan, Kyanzittha. The royal family would remain in exile for 25 years before returning to Pyinsa. According to legend, Kyanzittha sent an army of 100,000 Pyūs and 100,000 Tailangs to restore Min Bula's grandson, Letyaminnan (r. ca. 1103–1109) to the throne. Once restored to the throne, Letyaminnan moved the capital to Parein in 1103. Parein's day as the capital would come to an end when the last king of the Parein dynasty, Min Phu Sa, moved the capital to Hkrit in an effort to make the capital easier to defend.